VAYU | YOUR PERSONAL CROP GUIDE

Saffron

How to grow it on your land

Prepared for: General guide (no location chosen)
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Not a first-farm crop. It needs engineered climate control, imported corms and technical skill, and published indoor protocols are still being standardised. Visit or train with a working unit before spending money.

DIFFICULTY	MONEY NEEDED	RISK	FIRST RETURN
5 of 5	**High**	**High**	**first flowers about 3-4 months after planting corms**

How to read this guide: [S1] marks a line backed by a source listed on the last page. (general knowledge) marks a line that has not been verified against a source. Lines starting **For your land** use the numbers for your location.

In this guide

- Your priorities: what to do first, in order
- How to grow it: planting, water, nutrition, pests and diseases, monitoring, harvest, risks
- If your conditions are different, and the sources behind every line

Your land at a glance

What you would need to build

An insulated room with chillers, humidifiers and grow lights (aeroponic racks or trays) that recreates kashmir's cold, humid cycle. Corms are planted around July; flowering is induced by a cold spell and comes around October-November.

Your priorities

Ordered by what matters most on your land.

1. Build only after you have seen one working
Visit or train with an operating unit before you spend money on a room, equipment or planting material. (general knowledge)

2. Talk to your KVK first
Take this guide to your nearest Krishi Vigyan Kendra and ask for their local advice and trusted planting material. (general knowledge)

3. Start small
Plant or build a small trial first. Learn the crop on your own land, then expand from what actually worked. (general knowledge)

4. Line up a buyer before you scale
Know who will buy, in what form and grade, and how it will reach them. (general knowledge)

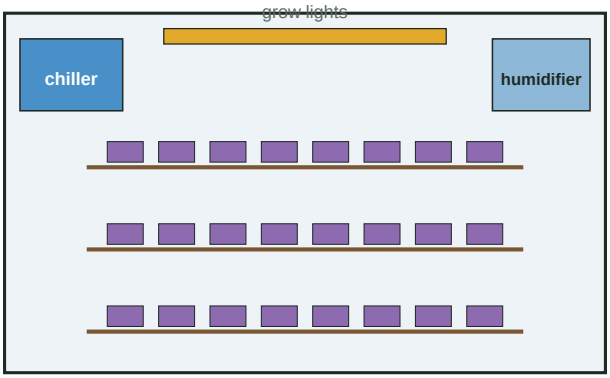
Planting material

- Buy graded corms from Pampore, Kashmir (SKUAST-Kashmir or a reputable grower). Corms of about 7-8 g and above are used; bigger corms flower more. [S1, S3, S7]
- Treat the corm bill as the main upfront cost: one reported indoor grower paid about Rs 8 lakh for a tonne of corms and Rs 6.5 lakh for the room. One personal example, not a typical cost. [S5]

Land preparation and planting

- Open field (Kashmir): plant 15-30 July, at 15-20 cm depth, on raised or well-drained beds; rows 20-25 cm apart. Delayed planting lowers first-year flowers. [S3, S7]
- Indoor: a thermally insulated room with chillers, humidifiers, light and CO2 control; clean, restricted-entry space. [S1, S2, S6]

- There is no single proven indoor protocol yet; a state horticultural university described its own project as a pilot that will produce standard operating procedures. [S1]



insulated room: temperature and humidity set for each stage; restricted entry

An engineered indoor growing room

Irrigation

- Open field: pre- and post-flowering irrigation raises flowering and corm yield; rain or irrigation in August-September helps early flowering. Keep drainage open to avoid corm rot. [S8, S3]
- Indoor aeroponic: nutrient mist delivered on a timed schedule; humidity about 60-70 percent is reported. [S1, S6]
- Stop watering during summer dormancy. [S4]

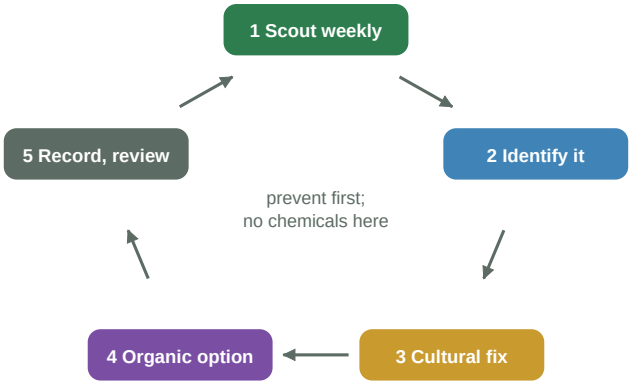
Nutrition (organic)

- Organic matter (well-rotted farmyard manure or compost) in beds for open field; indoors, follow your supplier's nutrient plan. (general knowledge)

Pests and diseases (organic and cultural only)

- Corm rot (fungal) is the commonest cause of failure, driven by wet soil and poor hygiene. Use drained beds, strict cleanliness and limit entry to the room. [S3, S4, S6]
- Remove and destroy affected corms at once; growers report using neem oil on affected corms. [S6]
- Rodents are a major open-field problem; reduce bunds and hiding places, and use traps. [S7]
- The Kashmir package suggests a fungicide dip before planting; this guide does not name or dose chemicals. Ask SKUAST-Kashmir or your KVK for an organic or biocontrol alternative. [S7]

- For anything beyond these organic and cultural steps, ask the nearest Krishi Vigyan Kendra (KVK) or state agricultural university for their current recommendation. (general knowledge)



Pest and disease loop: prevent first, then look, fix, review

Monitoring

- Check temperature and humidity daily with a logger; check corms weekly for soft, discoloured or mouldy patches. (general knowledge)
- Track sprouting date, flower initiation and flower count against your temperature schedule. (general knowledge)

Harvest, yield and post-harvest

- Flowers are picked by hand in the morning when open; stigmas are separated and dried below about 55 C. [S1, S3]
- Reported sale prices (several lakh rupees per kg, sometimes more) come from news and grower claims and are not verified; the quantity from a small room is small. Do your own numbers with a real buyer. [S9, S5]

Risks and costs

- Capital is high (cooling, humidity, lights, electricity, corms) and failure from heat, power cuts or corm rot is costly. (general knowledge)
- Saffron has a premium market partly because of Kashmir's origin and certification; confirm how you would sell and what a buyer will accept. (general knowledge)
- Anyone starting should first train or visit an operating unit; SKUAST-Kashmir and Telangana Horticultural University both run or advertise training. [S1, S2]

If your conditions are different

What to do if your land, or the season, turns out different from the numbers above.

- **Climate** (blocking): Open-field saffron depends on a cold winter and a dry summer dormancy. Outside the Kashmir-type climate the realistic route is a controlled indoor room, which is an engineering and capital decision, not a farming one. [S1, S2, S3]
- **Climate control** (fixable): Indoor growers report a warm phase (about 15-20 C) for sprouting and a cold flowering phase (single digits to about 17 C). Reported figures differ between sources, so use a trained supplier's schedule, not a blog's. [S4, S6]

About chemicals

This guide gives organic and cultural methods only. It does not name or dose pesticides, fungicides or chemical fertilisers; for those, follow your nearest Krishi Vigyan Kendra (KVK) or state agricultural university and the label of any registered product.

Sources

[S1] https://telanganatoday.com/saffron-from-telangana-horticulture-university-tries-soil-less-farming
[S2] https://www.deccanchronicle.com/amp/southern-states/telangana/aeroponic-saffron-flowers-bloom-in-telangana-1916878
[S3] https://nmhs.org.in/w/pdf/List_of_SOPs_25_July_2022/38.SOP_on_Saffron_cultivation_Dr.M.H.Khan/Saffron_Culltivation_and_beverage_prodution.pdf
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[S9] https://www.tribuneindia.com/news/punjab/kashmirs-saffron-blossoms-in-ludhianas-phulawal-village/

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